Hinduism

Quick Facts: Hinduism

Name: Hinduism is a collective term for all the diverse native religious traditions of India, except for reform movements such as Buddhism, Jainism, and Sikhism, which reject the authority of the Vedas and the Brahmin priests.

Founder: None, though the Brahmin class of priests are the source of the religious texts and control religious practice and sacrifice.

Gods: A range of beliefs, from pantheism and polytheism to monotheism; innumerable deities, including Vishnu, Shiva, Devi, Krishna, Ganesha, and Rama.

Calendar: Various calendars and dating methods are used.

Location: Originated around the Indus River in northwest India; spread throughout India. Found today mainly in India, with pockets of emigrants to other lands.

Primary Texts: The Vedas, Brahmanas, Aranyakas, and Upanishads. The most popular text, the Bhagavad Gita, is not found within those scriptural collections.

Main Ideas: Karma (a cosmic law of "reaping what you sow" and rebirth [reincarnation]). Liberation (moksha) from the cycle of rebirth (samsara) is gained by various paths: of Devotion, of Action, and of Knowledge.

Life Cycle: Four stages of life: student, householder, retired (hermit), and renouncer (wandering ascetic).

Hierarchy: No central authority, though ascetic holy men and Brahmin priests play important roles.

Major Sects: Most Hindus belong to sects associated with Vishnu and his avatars; Shiva and related deities; or Devi, the goddess and her manifestations.

Subgroups: Hindu society has long been controlled by the caste system, which binds individuals to occupations and circles of social contact. Four major classes exist: Brahmin (priests), Kshatriya (warriors/rulers), Vaishya (merchants), and Shudra (laborers/servants); the rest are considered outside the class system (untouchables). Thousands of castes exist within these class divisions. Caste barriers are officially (but ineffectively) outlawed in India.

Symbols

Cow: Symbol of fecundity and prosperity, the cow is venerated by Hindus, who will not kill or eat it. It is symbolically linked with Krishna, the cowherd deity.

Divine Images: Hinduism abounds with images (murti) of deities whose extraordinary appearance immediately conveys their transhuman nature. Multiple arms, wielding weapons or other items, symbolize the deity's powers, while specific postures and gestures (mudras) convey messages about the deity's nature, mythological acts, or teachings.

Linga: Cylindrical stone effigy of the male reproductive organ and symbol of Shiva.

Om/Aum: Perhaps the most sacred syllable or utterance (mantra) in Hinduism. It embodies Absolute Reality and is the sound that encapsulate all sound. It is chanted in meditation and precedes most Vedic prayers.

Svastika: An ancient symbol of well-being (svasti) and auspiciousness; often used to decorate entrances of homes and temples and inscribed on sacred objects.

Yoni: Stone receptacle into which a linga is often placed. Effigy of the female procreative organ and symbol of the Devi, it is regarded as the source from which creation emerges. The linga/yoni conveys that the Absolute embodies, yet transcends, male and female principles.

Groups/Divisions

Hindu society is divided into over three thousand castes (jati), social groups into which one is born and within which one is expected to marry. The castes are distributed within four major classes (varna), the first three of which are regarded as "twice-born" (dvija). The political and economic meaning o caste is changing, but traditional values continue to influence Hindu social interactions.

Brahmin: The priestly class. They retain and closely guard their authority to learn and teach the Vedas; this authority is generally respected due to their association with religious knowledge and spiritual purity.

Kshatriya: The ruling class. Members of this group of kings, warriors, and landlords held the power to rule and govern. Their duty was to protect the land and its people. They were entitled to learn the Vedas, but not teach it. Nowadays, anyone may enlist in the armed forces in India.

Vaishya: The mercantile class. They too were entitled to study but not teach the Vedas. They raised cattle, farmed, and traded. They constituted the economic backbone of the society. Nowadays, business in India is not conducted exclusively by members of this class.

Shudra: The servant class. Their duty was to serve the other classes. Since they were not one of the "twice-born" classes, they were not entitled to study the Vedas. They owned little wealth or property. Today, Shudras may rise to any position in Indian society, but they are still restricted by the traditional religious values that endure among segments of Hindus.

Untouchables: The classless group, many of whom prefer to call themselves Dalits (downtrodden). They consisted of outsiders and the lowest status individuals, often with the most inferior and defiling occupations. They are believed capable of spiritually polluting the "twice-born" merely through contact. Dalits have been struggling to free themselves from the stigma of their religious status in Hinduism within modern, secular Indian society.

Defining the Hindu

While scholars have been hard-pressed to find suitable definitions for what it means to be a Hindu, the Indian Supreme Court has produced the following set of workable criteria.

1. The Vedas should be accepted and revered as the foundation of Hindu philosophy.

2. One should have a spirit of tolerance and, recognizing that truth has many sides, be willing to understand and appreciate the viewpoints of others.

3. One accepts belief in recurring cosmic cycles of creation, preservation, and dissolution spanning vast amounts of time.

4. One accepts belief in reincarnation.

5. One recognizes that there are numerous paths to truth and salvation.

6. One recognizes that although the worship of idols may be deemed unnecessary, there may be many deities (gods and goddesses) worthy of worship.

7. In distinction from followers of other religions, one does not believe in a specific set of theological or philosophical conceptions.

Places

Dozens of places are highly revered by Hindus. These are a few important ones.

Ayodhya: Birthplace and capital city of the mythic god-king Rama.

Badrinath: One of four pilgrimage sites at a source of the River Ganga, and the location of a temple dedicated to Vishnu.

Haridwar: One of the seven sacred cities of the Hindus. It lies at the foothills of the Himalayas, where the Ganga descends to the plains. About thirty miles upstream lies Rishikesh, another city popular for its many yoga and meditation retreat centers (ashrams).

Kanchipuram: One of the most influential monastic centers of Hindu orthodoxy, reputedly established by the philosopher Shankara.

Prayag (Allahabad): A city on the River Ganga, where millions of Hindu pilgrims gather for a purifying bath during the Kumbha Mela.

Shrirangam: Great South Indian temple complex dedicated to Vishnu. It is a center of qualified nondualistic Vedanta philosophy.

Varanasi (Banaras): An ancient city located on the River Ganga (Ganges) and renowned as a center of Vedic learning. It contains temples to many deities but is regarded as particularly dedicated to the god Shiva.

Texts

The Vedas: The most revered literature in Hinduism, possessing the status of shruti (divinely heard teachings). There are four sets of Vedic texts, known as the Rig, Sama, Yajur, and Atharv Vedas.

The Upanishads: The last portion of each of the sets of Vedic texts. The Upanishads contain philosophical speculation about the nature of reality, the relationship between the Atman and Brahman, and the notion of liberation (moksha).

The Epics: The two great epics, the Ramayana and the Mahabharata, provide useful information (e.g., social, geographical) not found in the Vedas.

The Ramayana recounts the exploits of the prince Rama, Vishnu's seventh incarnation. The Mahabharata recounts the adventures of the Pandavas, five heroic brothers who fight to regain their kingdom.

The Bhagavad Gita (lit., "The Song of the Lord"): A portion of the Mahabharata, consisting of a conversation about the purpose of existence between Krishna, a human incarnation of Vishnu, and the warrior Arjuna.

The Puranas: Large, often sectarian, pseudohistorical compendiums, containing mythological accounts of the creation, favorite post-Vedic deities, royal dynasties, and holy places.

The Tantras: A vast assortment of texts, often written as teachings by a deity such as Shiva or the Devi, emphasizing ritual, spiritual practice, and the feminine Divine. They criticize orthodox Hindu practices as inferior or elementary.

Deities

The following became popular in the post-Vedic period and are widely worshiped today.

Shiva: In early theology, identified with the destructive principle of the cosmos. To devotees of Shiva, he is the supreme deity who reconciles the seeming polarities of creation and destruction. Shiva is worshiped in the form of a symbolic erect phallus (linga).

Vishnu: All-pervading, and often depicted blue like the sky. Vishnu, through his incarnations (avatara), preserves righteousness when forces of chaos and unrighteousness threaten the cosmic order. Vishnu is generally portrayed as a cosmic king, resting on an endless serpent.

Devi: The Great Goddess, also called Durga, the source and summation of all female deities, and the power (Shakti) that animates the entire cosmos. She embodies both a fierce and a benign nature.

Ganesha: Popular, elephant-headed, potbellied deity; leader of Shiva's forces who presides over obstacles.

Krishna: Eighth incarnation of Vishnu; featured in the epic Mahabharata.

Lakshmi: The goddess of prosperity and good fortune, often linked with her consort Vishnu; also known as Shri. She is depicted as a beautiful woman seated on a lotus.

Kali: Dark, fierce goddess who symbolizes time and destruction. Kali is often depicted naked, with disheveled hair and a garland of skulls.

Hanuman: The monkey god; he is often worshiped as a protector.

The Four Goals or Aims

The following are regarded by Hindus as the most worthwhile objectives in life.

Artha: The pursuit of wealth, power, and attainments through the development of one's potential.

Dharma: An understanding of the meaning of duty or righteousness and its application in one's life.

Kama: Knowledge of love, sexual and sensual pleasure, joy, and happiness.

Moksha: Liberation through Self-realization from the bondage to worldly existence and the cycles of reincarnation.

Leaders

Shankara (eighth to ninth century CE): South Indian renouncer, known for his Vedanta philosophy of radical nondualism (advaita). Brahman, which has no attributes, is regarded as the absolute and only reality. The apparent diversity in creation is the result of maya, the power of illusion. Shankara is also credited with creating the first Hindu monastic system.

Ramanuja (ca. 1017–1137): Proponent of Qualified Nondualistic Vedanta, in which Brahman is the only reality but possesses attributes (saguna), such as compassion and grace. Manifest reality is not an illusion but reflects Brahman's glory.

Madhva (ca. 1199–1278): Taught a dualistic (dvaita) Vedanta, in which Brahman is different from human souls and the creation.

Chaitanya (1486–1533): Bengali saint who popularized public dance and chanting as a form of devotion to Krishna. The Hare Krishna movement (a.k.a. ISKCON), founded in 1966 by A. C. Bhaktivedanta, developed from Chaitanya's organization.

Ram Mohan Roy (1772–1833): Founder of the Brahmo Samaj, an organization that emphasized rationalism, humanism, and social reform; fought against practices such as widow burning (sati).

Swami Vivekananda (1862–1902): Founder of the Ramakrishna movement; influenced the West's knowledge of Hinduism.

Mahatma Gandhi (1869–1948): Proponent of active but nonviolent resistance to oppression, which was used in the struggle for Indian independence from British rule.

Yogas

Yogas are paths of physical and psychological practices in which the goal is liberation (moksha). There are numerous types of yoga in Hindu practice.

These are some of the most well-known.

Bhakti Yoga: An approach introduced in the Bhagavad Gita, calling for loving devotion (bhakti to a deity. Devotional worship (puja) is the most common way in which loving devotion is expressed, although it may take other forms, such as prayer, song, and pilgrimage.

Hatha Yoga: A yoga emphasizing posture (asana) and breath work. It is popular in the West since the focus is on physical and psychological health.

Jnana Yoga: A path that centers on the intellect and is regarded as difficult. Scriptural study, inquiry into the question "Who am I?," and meditation may be regarded as belonging to this quest for transcendental knowledge (jnana).

Karma Yoga: A path of selfless action (karma) described in the Bhagavad Gita. It emphasizes detachment from the outcome of all actions, which should be performed in a spirit of sacrifice to the divine.

Kundalini Yoga: The yoga of the coiled (kundalini) energy, envisioned as a dormant serpent. In Hindu Tantrism, this awakened energy is understood to convey supernatural powers.

Raja Yoga: Royal Yoga, which centers on stopping the "turnings of thought" and offers eight aspects (limbs) that need to be developed to perfect it.

Offices

Guru: One's teacher. Generally used to designate the most important guide and mentor in one's spiritual development.

Priest: One who presides over the performance of religious rituals. Priests conduct rituals in shrines and temples, but also at rites such as marriage and death. Priests are mainly Brahmin males, but on rare occasions lower-caste women perform priestly roles in the worship of certain goddesses.

Sadhu: A generic term used to designate any Hindu holy man. These include members of monastic institutions and itinerant ascetics.

Swami: A title bestowed on those who have become renouncers through certain organizations, such as the orders founded by Shankara or Chaitanya.

Yogi: A person who is wholly committed to the discipline of yoga, a philosophy promulgating the complete integration of oneself with the Absolute through specific, often austere, psychophysical practices.

The Four Stages of Life

The following are traditionally prescribed for "twice-born" males. Student (shishya): Originally a period of formal Vedic education with a spiritual mentor (guru). Also known as brahmacharya, since the student was supposed to lead a pure, austere lifestyle and remain celibate.

Householder (grihastha): Married life, during which one is expected to conduct household rituals, contribute to society, and raise children, particularly a male heir.

Forest-dweller (vanaprastha): Option prescribed for grandparents or the elderly. It involves retiring to the forest to live a simple life dedicated to religious study.

Renouncer (samnyasin): Highly esteemed option. It requires conducting one's own death rituals, abandoning spouse and society, and living entirely off the alms given by others.

Rites and Rituals

Birth and Early Childhood: There is an assortment of Hindu prenatal rites: some to enhance the chances of producing male offspring, others to enhance the mother's fertility or the safety of childbirth. One rite designates the exact time of birth, for horoscopic purposes. Others, such as the first tonsure, demarcate stages in the child's development.

Sacred Thread: Males of the "twice-born" classes, particularly Brahmins, are given a sacred utterance (mantra) to repeat and a loop of sacred thread to wear over their left shoulders. This is done traditionally between ages eight and thirteen and introduces the student stage of life and the study of the Vedas.

Marriage: Generally arranged by parents within the appropriate caste, often involving horoscopic consultations. Marriage formally initiates men and women into the householder stage of life, enabling them to fulfill their societal obligations by raising children.

Death: Regarded as the final sacrifice in a person's life. Death rites transform the deceased's spirit from the state of a ghost (preta) to that of an ancestor and restore the family to spiritual purity. Bodies are cremated, and the ashes are strewn into a sacred body of water.

Renunciation: An optional rite of passage prescribed for people in their old age. Renouncers (samnyasin) must perform their own death rituals and strive to be detached from family and material desires. They often wear ochre-colored robes and depend on almsgiving for their livelihood.

Festivals

Dozens of festivals are celebrated by Hindus, with many regional variations. Dates follow a lunar calendar and thus vary each year. The following are a few that are pan-Indian.

Divali: A festival of lights celebrated on the new moon between mid-October and mid-November. Homes are painted and decorated with lamps firecrackers are set off, and people buy new clothes and feast. The festival marks the victory of light over darkness and begins the new year for many communities.

Navaratra: A nine-night festival linked to the new moon between mi September and mid October. It is dedicated to the Devi, who is worshiped in a variety of forms, especially as Durga.

Holi: Celebrated in February/March. It commemorates the defeat of the demoness Holika. Exuberant throwing of colored water and powder marks this festival in which the restrictions on gender and intercaste interactions are partially suspended.

Mahashivaratri: Celebrated in honor of Shiva. Devotees fast during the day and worship symbols of Shiva (lingas) throughout the night with offerings of milk and Ganga water.

Kumbha Mela: A pilgrimage to a specific part of a sacred river, such as the Ganga, taking place every twelve years. The Kumbha Mela held at Allahabad (Prayag) is the largest gathering of people in the world, attracting over fifteen million who seek purification by ritual bathing.

Terminology

Brahman (lit., "the Expansive"): This is one of several Hindu words that derive from the Sanskrit verbal root brih, "to expand." Brahman refers to the all-encompassing Absolute Reality. The Brahmanas are Vedic ritual texts.

The Brahmins are members of the priestly class, while Brahma is the name of the Hindu creator god.

Self: Numerous Sanskrit terms are used to describe one's inner spirit or soul (e.g., jiva, atman, purusha). However, because of the pervasive influence of nondualistic Vedanta philosophies, the term Atman is most often translated as "Self." This Self is generally distinguished from the idea of a personal soul, because it is often regarded as transpersonal, even being equated with Absolute Reality (i.e., Brahman).

Shruti (lit., "divinely heard"): This category is applied by orthodox Hindus exclusively to the Vedic Samhitas, the Brahmanas, the Aranyakas, and the Upanishads—collectively called the Vedas. The divine origin attributed to these texts gives them a status akin to the "revealed scriptures" of other traditions.

Smriti (lit., "remembered"): This category of Hindu sacred writings includes all that is not shruti. It includes the epics, the Puranas, and the Tantras, although it is especially applied to the Dharma Shastras, which are sometimes collectively called smriti. Certain smriti texts, such as the Bhagavad Gita, although not classified as shruti, are treated by many Hindus as divinely revealed.